

Chapter 32-8

//

Liang Shi returned empty-handed, but felt that Teacher Qi's behavior was somewhat strange.

But it could also be explained as being afraid of strangers.

That evening, Xu Qingzhu still came home very late.

Liang Shi waited for her to return before going to her room.

Occasionally when Liang Shi woke up in the early morning hours, she would impulsively go to the living room and discover the study light was still on, with Xu Qingzhu still staying up late working on proposals.

There wasn't much she could help with, so she would heat up a cup of milk and bring it over.

One night when she went in, Xu Qingzhu was looking at design drafts.

She was clearly exhausted beyond measure, her eyelids drooping, but she propped up her eyelids with both hands as she sat there looking, the whole person drowsy.

The sound of Liang Shi pushing the door startled Xu Qingzhu. She immediately sat up straight, but couldn't help yawning, "You're not asleep yet?"

"I already had a full night's sleep and woke up," Liang Shi said. "You can't keep working overtime like this forever."

"Everyone in our department is working overtime," Xu Qingzhu's voice was muffled as she made a fist and gently knocked her head, putting her glasses back on to look at the design drafts. "I can't make special exceptions."

"You could take it slowly," Liang Shi said. "If you exhaust your body like this, there won't be anyone who can step up when the time comes."

"The autumn fashion show is about to begin," Xu Qingzhu said. "Every day now is a countdown for me. There's simply no possibility of rest."

Liang Shi: "..."

Seeing Xu Qingzhu constantly knocking her head, she asked, "Do you have a headache?"

"From staying up too much," Xu Qingzhu said. "A little."

Liang Shi raised an eyebrow, "Should I massage it for you?"

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together and looked up at her. She was standing in a backlit position, wearing blue silk pajamas—long sleeves and long pants—with her long hair casually loose on both sides of her shoulders. Her face was gentle, and her gaze was also very tender.

As if struck by softness.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly smiled, "That would trouble you."

"No problem," Liang Shi walked behind her and reached out to press on her temples, deliberately avoiding looking at her computer screen.

Xu Qingzhu's slender fingers clicked on the mouse, and soon she was typing content in a notebook document. After a while, Xu Qingzhu suddenly asked, "Would you like to help me look at this sample design?"

Liang Shi was surprised, "Can I look at it?"

Xu Qingzhu: "...Now you can."

Design drafts, especially those before new product launches, were all classified internal company materials.

Once leaked, they could potentially have a huge impact on a company.

So Xu Qingzhu had been slightly cautious before, but the biggest problem was that day when she came in, she was on a call with Sally and didn't really want Liang Shi to hear.

Actually, letting Liang Shi look at the design drafts was fine, since Dongheng Group had invested a lot of money.

They were grasshoppers on the same rope¹.

The sample designs on screen had been 3D processed, so they weren't difficult to look at.

"What should I look for?" Liang Shi asked.

"Find flaws," Xu Qingzhu said. "This is a design Lin Luoxi created. She never sees problems with her own work, but she has high standards for herself and asked me to tell her at least three flaws tomorrow. And I think this looks weird too, Sally also thinks it's weird, but we can't say what's weird about it."

Because this design draft was indeed stunning at first glance.

But then it would seem increasingly strange the more you looked at it.

Liang Shi was surprised when she first saw it. It used autumn's high concept, integrating starry sky and cosmic elements, taking already overused elements and presenting them anew, with every detail executed to perfection. It was a bold style with very innovative design.

But she had the same feeling as Xu Qingzhu—stunning at first glance, then feeling somewhat off.

"Is this just one image?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head and scrolled down, "This is an autumn series, twenty-four images total, but this is the basic model. The rest are all modifications based on this one."

Liang Shi nodded, "Scroll down."

Xu Qingzhu was distracted and didn't hear, "What?"

A thought flashed through Liang Shi's mind, but she hadn't accurately captured it yet. In her urgency, she directly reached out to grasp the mouse.

Xu Qingzhu's hand was on the mouse.

Liang Shi's hand was slightly larger than Xu Qingzhu's, covering it perfectly.

Her gaze was fixed intently on the screen as she pressed the mouse and scrolled down.

She looked at each image for no more than three seconds, and after browsing all the images, she returned to the first image and suddenly said with certainty, "I know what the problem is."

Xu Qingzhu's gaze had originally been on her hand, but upon hearing this, she immediately asked, "Where?"

"Look at this, her color is sky blue, leaning toward deep blue tones, which doesn't match most people's wearing habits. And this inner ring design, although it's studded with stars, there are too many of them, making it look very complex, like this one." Liang Shi flipped to the twenty-third image, "This one is just right, the perfect degree."

"Also, aren't you going for autumn's high concept? This image's design looks more like spring, using colors that are too green. Better to change it to fallen leaf yellow, that light orange color."

"..."

Liang Shi spoke eloquently at the desk, pouring out all her opinions. Xu Qingzhu listened carefully, following her train of thought to analyze, and finally understood.

She smiled, "That's right."

"We've been looking at drafts so much recently that we can't spot problems at all," Xu Qingzhu said. "Sometimes the problems are actually quite obvious."

"I just happened to stumble upon it like a blind cat catching a dead mouse²," Liang Shi said modestly. "Hurry up and write this, finish writing and go to sleep. You'll definitely be drowsy at work tomorrow."

"There's coffee," Xu Qingzhu said. "Which office worker doesn't stay up late?"

"But I've never seen anyone who stays up as intensely as you," Liang Shi said. "Let me drive you to work tomorrow, you can sleep a bit in the car."

Xu Qingzhu paused, originally wanting to refuse but the words that came out were, "Okay, thank you."

"Then hurry up and write," Liang Shi said. "I won't disturb you anymore."

"Mm," Xu Qingzhu responded quietly, but didn't start writing. Liang Shi asked, "Why aren't you writing?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Xu Qingzhu's gaze moved from Liang Shi's chin all the way to her right hand, seeing that her hand was still covering Xu Qingzhu's hand.

Liang Shi was startled and immediately pulled back her hand, stammering, "I, I, I, I... I didn't mean to."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Seeing her like this, Xu Qingzhu couldn't help but laugh, "It's fine."

Liang Shi's ears turned red, "I'm going out now."

"Go ahead, sleep early," Xu Qingzhu said.

But before Liang Shi left, Xu Qingzhu suddenly said, "Liang Shi, are you free this Friday evening?"

"Yes," Liang Shi said. "What's up?"

"I have a friend returning from abroad who wants to meet you. When we got married, she didn't know, so she wants me to bring you to apologize to her," Xu Qingzhu said this with a wandering gaze, unsure if Liang Shi would agree.

The main thing was that Sally's additional condition for returning to help was to meet her wife.

Sally had just returned and been dragged by her to help at the company, not even adjusting to the time difference before directly helping her start working on design drafts.

Lin Luoxi also hadn't slept for several nights.

They were both quite concerned about her married life, so they strongly requested she bring her wife out for a meal together, or come to their house.

Xu Qingzhu felt it was better to meet outside. If they came to her house, she'd have to share a room with Liang Shi again.

Worried that Liang Shi might agree without knowing anything, Xu Qingzhu added, "She has a really high alcohol tolerance."

"My alcohol tolerance isn't bad either," Liang Shi immediately said. "No problem. Should I book a private room? Your company is pretty busy lately, right?"

"I'll book it," Xu Qingzhu said. "I know what they like to eat. You just need to come directly when the time comes."

"Okay."

Footnotes:

¹ Grasshoppers on the same rope: Chinese idiom meaning people who share the same fate or are in the same situation

² Blind cat catching a dead mouse: Chinese idiom meaning to succeed by luck rather than skill